HEALING BEYOND DIAGNOSIS INITIATIVE
HBDI
CAREGIVER SUPPORT TOOLKIT
Practical tools for the person supporting someone through life-changing diagnosis, disability, injury, chronic illness, or major health transition
Caregiving can begin before someone ever uses the word "caregiver."
This package is designed to help caregivers recognize their role, prepare for transitions, identify their own needs, communicate clearly, and connect with support before exhaustion becomes crisis.
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HEALING BEYOND DIAGNOSIS INITIATIVE

About This Toolkit

A spouse, parent, adult child, sibling, friend, or other support person may suddenly be coordinating appointments, managing changes at home, helping with daily activities, advocating for services, or supporting someone whose abilities, personality, energy, communication, or independence have changed.

HBDI's caregiver tools are intended to make the caregiver visible within the recovery process. They focus on earlier recognition, realistic preparation, emotional adjustment, communication, resource connection, and the caregiver's own identity and well-being.

Use this toolkit in the way that helps most.

It can be completed privately, used to prepare for a healthcare or service-provider conversation, shared with a family member, or revisited as circumstances change.

HBDI Support and Resource Navigation

For current HBDI services, caregiver supports, and guidance on finding relevant resources, visit our main website. Available programs and access requirements may change; the website is the best place to start.

Visit HBDI: https://healingbeyonddiagnosis.ca/

These worksheets are educational reflection tools. They are not a diagnosis or a substitute for an individualized professional assessment.

The tools in this package

[ ] Caregiver Check-In
[ ] "Am I a Caregiver?" Recognition Tool
[ ] Hospital-to-Home Preparedness Check
[ ] Caregiver Role Change & Ambiguous Loss Reflection
[ ] What Has Changed for Me?
[ ] Caregiver Communication Planner
[ ] Caregiver Support Circle
[ ] Resource Navigation Support
[ ] The "You Still Matter" Check-In

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1. Caregiver Check-In

A brief self-reflection tool to help notice strain before exhaustion becomes crisis. This is not a
diagnostic test. It is a way to identify areas that may need support.

Think about the past 1-2 weeks.

Check anything that feels true often enough that it is affecting you, your health, your relationships, or your ability to provide care.

[ ] I feel physically exhausted.
[ ] I feel emotionally overwhelmed or constantly "on."
[ ] My sleep is poor or interrupted.
[ ] I am becoming more isolated from people or activities I value.
[ ] My relationship with the person I support has changed in ways that are difficult for me.
[ ] I am unsure whether I am doing enough or doing the right things.
[ ] I do not have enough practical help.
[ ] I rarely get a meaningful break from caregiving responsibilities.
[ ] I worry frequently about what will happen next.
[ ] I am unsure where to turn for information, services, or support.
[ ] My own health or responsibilities are being neglected.

What stands out most right now?

_____
_____
_____
_____

One thing that would make this week easier:

_____
_____
_____

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2. "Am I a Caregiver?" Recognition Tool

Many people provide significant care without identifying themselves as caregivers. Recognizing the role matters because support is easier to seek when the work being done is visible.

[ ] I manage or help coordinate appointments.
[ ] I help with medications or treatment routines.
[ ] I provide transportation because of the person's health or disability.
[ ] I help with meals, household tasks, personal care, mobility, or other daily needs.
[ ] I monitor safety or watch for changes in symptoms, behaviour, cognition, or functioning.
[ ] I advocate with healthcare, disability, insurance, social-service, or community systems.
[ ] I provide regular emotional reassurance or crisis support.
[ ] I have taken on responsibilities the other person used to manage.
[ ] My schedule, employment, finances, family responsibilities, or social life have changed because of the care I provide.

If several of these describe your life, you may be functioning as a caregiver even if you have never used that word.

Recognizing the role does not change your relationship with the person you support. It may simply make it easier to recognize that you also deserve information, preparation, and support.

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3. Hospital-to-Home Preparedness Check

Transitions from hospital, rehabilitation, or formal care to home can create hidden responsibilities for families. Use this check before discharge when possible, or afterward to identify missing information.

[ ] I understand what care will be required at home.
[ ] I understand the person's current limitations and what they can safely do independently.
[ ] I know what changes or warning signs should cause concern.
[ ] I know who to contact if something changes or goes wrong.
[ ] I have been shown how to perform any care tasks I am expected to perform.
[ ] I understand medications, follow-up appointments, equipment, therapies, or restrictions.
[ ] The home environment is reasonably prepared for the person's needs.
[ ] My own physical, emotional, time, and financial limitations have been considered.
[ ] I know which community services or supports have been recommended.
[ ] I understand what to do if a recommended service is unavailable, delayed, or not a fit.

Questions I still need answered before I feel prepared:

_____
_____
_____
_____
_____

A caregiver being present does not automatically mean a care plan is realistic.
It is appropriate to say what you can safely manage, what you cannot manage, and what support is needed to make the transition workable.

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4. Caregiver Role Change & Ambiguous Loss Reflection

Not all grief follows death. A person can still be present while important parts of a relationship,
future, routine, independence, or shared identity have changed. This is often described as ambiguous
loss.

[ ] Our relationship roles have changed.
[ ] Shared plans or expectations for the future have changed.
[ ] The person’s independence has changed.
[ ] Communication, personality, behaviour, cognition, or emotional availability has changed.
[ ] Intimacy or companionship has changed.
[ ] Family responsibilities have shifted.
[ ] Our financial situation or work life has changed.
[ ] Our social life has changed.
[ ] I feel grief even though the person I care about is still here.
[ ] I sometimes feel guilty for grieving what has changed.

Two things can be true at the same time.
"I love this person." AND "I am grieving what has changed." Recognizing grief does not diminish love, loyalty, or commitment.

What am I grieving that I rarely say out loud?

_____
_____
_____
_____
_____

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5. What Has Changed for Me?

Caregiving can change a person's identity gradually. This exercise creates space to notice what has changed without assuming that everything must return to the way it was before.

Before

What did my life normally look like?

_____

What responsibilities did I have?

_____

What gave me energy or purpose?

_____

Who could I rely on?

_____

What did my relationship with this person look like?

_____

Now

What responsibilities have changed?

_____

What have I stopped doing?

_____

What am I carrying that others may not see?

_____

What do I miss?

_____

What support do I need now?

_____

Moving Forward

What needs to remain?

_____

What can change?

_____

What can someone else help with?

_____

What is one part of myself I want to protect?

_____

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6. Caregiver Communication Planner

When caregiving becomes complicated, conversations can become emotional, rushed, or vague. This planner helps turn a concern into a clear request.

1. What is happening?

Describe the concern in one or two sentences.

_____

_____

2. What have I noticed?

Use specific examples rather than general statements.

_____

_____

3. What do I need?

Information, clarification, respite, services, training, equipment, follow-up, or another form of support.

_____

_____

4. Who needs to hear this?

Identify the person or service most likely to act on the concern.

_____

_____

5. What am I asking for?

End with a specific, realistic request.

_____

_____

Example language

"I can continue helping with X, but I cannot safely manage Y without additional support. What options are available?"

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7. Caregiver Support Circle

Caregivers are often told to "ask for help," but help is easier to request when the need is specific.

Identify at least one possible person, organization, or service in each area.

Area	What help could look like	Who/what could help?
Practical	Meals, errands, transportation, household tasks	
Care-related	Appointments, supervision, respite, equipment	
Emotional	Someone to talk to, peer support, counselling	
Administrative	Forms, benefits, scheduling, applications	
Emergency	Who can step in if I suddenly cannot provide care?	

Start small.

One reliable person or service in one category is more useful than a long list of people you do not feel comfortable contacting.

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8. Resource Navigation Support

Finding the right service can become another job on top of caregiving. The purpose of resource navigation is to reduce the amount of searching, repeating, and guessing required to find a useful
next step.

Before searching, identify the need

[ ] Caregiver support or respite
[ ] Mental health or emotional support
[ ] Home or community care
[ ] Disability supports
[ ] Financial or income support
[ ] Transportation
[ ] Housing or accessibility
[ ] Food or basic needs
[ ] Legal or advocacy support
[ ] Peer/community connection
[ ] Crisis or urgent support
[ ] Something else

Questions to ask any service

[ ] Who is eligible?
[ ] Is there a cost?
[ ] Is a referral required?
[ ] How long is the wait?
[ ] Is support available virtually or in my area?
[ ] What information should I have ready before calling?

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Specialized Caregiver Organizations

Different caregivers need different kinds of support. HBDI focuses on adults and families navigating changes after illness, injury, and disability. When children, teenagers, or young adults are taking on caregiving responsibilities, a specialized young-caregiver organization may be a better starting point.

Young Caregivers Association (YCA) | https://youngcaregivers.ca/

YCA supports young caregivers and their families. Its Powerhouse programs focus on ages 5-25, with some services offered in specific regions and some virtual support. Contact YCA to confirm eligibility, location, and current availability.

Ontario Caregiver Organization | https://ontariocaregiver.ca/

Ontario-wide caregiver information, learning tools, peer supports, and referrals. Caregiver Helpline:
1-833-416-2273 (24/7 by phone).

211 Ontario | https://211ontario.ca/

Search for community, social, and local practical support services. Availability and eligibility vary by area.

These organizations are independent resources. Listing them does not imply a formal referral agreement, endorsement, or guaranteed access to their services.

HBDI Resource Navigation

Explore current caregiver supports and community resource navigation at https://healingbeyonddiagnosis.ca/. The public HBDI resource navigator and local service options may change. You can also contact 211 Ontario for help identifying community supports.

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9. The "You Still Matter" Check-In

Caregiving can gradually reduce a person’s world to appointments, responsibilities, emergencies, and
the needs of someone else. This check-in is about preserving the caregiver’s identity as a person
outside of the caregiving role.

What do I need today?

_____
_____

What am I feeling that I have not acknowledged?

_____
_____

What have I done recently that was only for me?

_____
_____

What part of my own life needs attention?

_____
_____

Who knows how I am actually doing?

_____
_____

What is one part of myself I do not want caregiving to erase?

_____
_____

This is not generic "self-care."

It is a reminder that the caregiver remains a whole person with needs, relationships, health, goals, grief, and an identity that matters.

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When More Support Is Needed

A toolkit cannot solve every caregiving challenge. Consider reaching out for additional support when strain is persistent, safety is uncertain, responsibilities are beyond what can realistically be managed, or the caregiver's own health and functioning are being significantly affected.

Where to Find Current HBDI Support

Visit https://healingbeyonddiagnosis.ca/ for current HBDI services, caregiver information, and access to resource navigation.

A Note to Caregivers

You do not need to wait until you are overwhelmed to seek support. Caregiver support should begin when caregiving begins - not only when someone reaches burnout. HBDI's caregiver work is designed around earlier recognition, realistic preparation, emotional adjustment, resource connection, and helping caregivers remain visible within the recovery process.

Important Notice

This toolkit is intended for education, self-reflection, caregiver support, and resource navigation. It is not a diagnostic assessment, individualized treatment plan, or substitute for qualified healthcare, legal, or emergency advice. For immediate danger, call 911; for suicide-related crisis support in Canada, call or text 988.

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